Shared Activity Ideas

read-alouds and story chains that kids love

Read-alouds

- Pick a short chapter book and read one chapter per call — and stop at a good cliffhanger, so next call comes fast.
- Let the kid read a page and do all the voices. Then swap, and you do your best dragon impression.
- For little ones, choose picture books you can hold up to the camera and point at together.
- One short poem per call, then make up your own silly poem about something you can both see.
- Let the grandkid pick the book from a small menu of three choices — choosing is half the fun.

Story chains

- One person starts with "Once upon a time…" and each of you adds two sentences per turn.
- Keep the same silly characters from call to call, and grow the saga over months.
- Pick a theme bag — outer space, a dragon bakery, a traveling taco truck — and stay inside it.
- Write the story down in your keeper notes so it never gets lost between calls.
- Roll an imaginary dice to see who narrates next, or take turns by alphabet.

Golden rule of every activity: it should make both of you laugh before it ends.

Shared Activity Ideas

show-and-tell and quick games that work over any screen

Show-and-tell

- Keep the rule simple: each person shows exactly one thing, so turns stay quick and special.
- Do a VIP item of the week — two minutes to explain why it deserves the crown.
- Tour the trophy shelf: drawings, medals, and crafts. Your side counts too!
- Do a slow, wiggly room tour and let the other side ask one question at every stop.
- Adults can join in — show a keepsake and tell the story behind it (talk about it, no need to show private photos).

Quick games

- I Spy, backdrop edition: spy things in each other's rooms.
- Twenty Questions — animal, mineral, or household object.
- Screen scavenger hunt: find something red, something soft, something that makes a sound.
- Copy-cat freeze dance: one person strikes a pose, the other copies it and freezes.
- Two truths and a dream: two true facts and one wish — everyone guesses the dream.

Mix and match: one read-aloud, one game, and one chat-starter is a perfect call.